

What Unites INDIA

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Freedom abhors perfection. In the history of nations, it is a narrative in which idealism is in combat with ideology, and the romance of struggle gives in to the reality of incompatibility. Old demons in tattered but still colourful clothes of ethnicity and tribalism have the habit of gate-crashing the freedom party. Hate Rearmed patrols the liberated streets. In the evening of the last century, when the idyll of communism was shattered, when the Lie was finally laid to rest, we saw how the poignancy of freedom was accompanied by the agony of separation. Those were the days when the punsters of journalism could stretch their creativity, ranging from Mikhailangelo (Gorbachev) to Check-O-Slovakia. The story of 1989, Europe's *annus mirabilis*, would

outgrow the beauty of the Magic Lantern and the second Prague Spring. In Central Europe, the phraseology of liberation would be expanded to include "the Second Holocaust" and "ethnic cleansing". Today, as Mesopotamia stages the new century's passion play of freedom, we know the world hasn't gone too far. Freedom divides the mind, and it kills.

Then what is it that makes India a model to be emulated? You could find any number of pundits citing India as a rejoinder to the bloodlust of ethnicity and religion. The Nehruvian proverb of

unity-in-diversity has become an easy example of co-existence in the time of Iraq. There must be something here to be learned, something that is uniquely Indian. Sixty years ago, territorial separation was a pre-requisite for Independence. Still, with the passage of time, the sorrows of Partition have not been institutionalised as a national project in hate. For the Indian Muslim, home is never elsewhere. The Berlin Wall may have migrated to the mind of the liberated, but Partition has not divided the national mind. Pakistan is a bad memory, and a painful one, but